

Unimelb Library Evaluation

A privacy-safe summary of a mixed-method usability evaluation. It preserves the study logic, evidence scale and design recommendations while excluding names, student numbers, signatures, participant images, raw records and withdrawn third-party material.

14 online first-impression participants	5 moderated lab participants	5 representative tasks	8 prioritised recommendations
---	---------------------------------	---------------------------	----------------------------------

Ownership and contribution

This was a five-person university group project. Bowen Mai contributed to research planning, moderated evaluation work, observation, evidence synthesis and the final report. Concept development, sessions, analysis and submission were shared.

Publication boundary

This document is a new public summary, not the original submission. The complete unredacted report remains private because the study materials include confidential participant evidence and third-party identifiers.

From first impression to task performance

The online five-second test examined what the Library homepage communicated at a glance. Moderated lab sessions then tested whether students could complete everyday journeys. Completion, time, perceived difficulty, think-aloud comments, observation and gaze behaviour were read together.

First impression	Check audience, purpose and immediate hierarchy.	Five-second exposure and short recall questions.
Task performance	Test representative library journeys.	Room booking, APA 7, databases, past exams and journal download.
Behaviour evidence	Explain where each pathway broke down.	Completion, time, difficulty, observation, comments and gaze.
Design handoff	Turn findings into actionable priorities.	Eight recommendations retaining their report identifiers.

Scope

The sample was intentionally small and student-focused. The evidence supports a next design iteration, not population-level proof.

Three patterns explain the main friction

Room booking became the critical path	All five lab participants struggled; one did not finish within eight minutes.	The pathway lacked a clear sequence, progress cues and recovery messages.
Search results did not confirm relevance	Four participants were unsure whether the database results answered the task.	Results existed, but relevance and completion were weakly communicated.
Visible controls still lacked meaning	Attention dispersed across icons, fields and status areas.	Unlabelled controls and hidden eligibility rules forced trial and error.

Evidence responsibility

Gaze evidence was used diagnostically alongside observed behaviour and task data. It was not treated as a substitute for performance evidence or as proof about all users.

Eight findings became eight interface moves

R1	Guide booking step by step	Expose sequence and progress before the next stage.
R2	Reveal Create Reservation at the right moment	Make the primary action prominent when applicable.
R3	Explain ineligible spaces	Prevent dead ends with eligibility and recovery messages.
R4	Rename Re:Cite	Use Referencing and Citations for immediate legibility.
R5	Confirm the subject match	Explain why database results match the query.
R6	Surface All Filters	Increase visibility of the control used for past exams.
R7	Label utility icons	Pair functions with words such as Download PDF.
R8	Replace the green add icon	Use an explicit Select Space action.

Limitations

The online sample included 14 students and the moderated sample included 5 students. Think-aloud may have affected timing, and the task set focused on common journeys. Recommendations should guide a larger follow-up test.